

Vivienne Marrow

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling intended to announce that the Star Bowl would become a permanent Meridian holding, undermining months of quiet restitution negotiations and publicly humiliating the international partners you represent.

What you are hiding

You leaked the existence of the restitution talks to selected journalists to pressure Sterling, even though the negotiations were supposed to remain confidential. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Nadia knows you were the leak.
- Get Helena to acknowledge that the legal risk is real.
- Avoid turning the gala into a diplomatic incident unless Sterling's announcement forces you.

What you know about other guests

- Helena's original legal opinion was substantially more skeptical of the Star Bowl acquisition than the final version.
- Marcus believes Sterling has sat on provenance research that could embarrass the collection.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You delivered a formal letter to Sterling at 6:28. During the poison window, the Registrar's secure fax machine was transmitting your confidential restitution packet page by page under your authorization code. The transmission log clears your timing but exposes negotiations you were supposed to keep quiet.

IF MURDERER

At 6:46 you returned with a second envelope containing a final demand. When Sterling refused, you poisoned the cordial. You discarded the envelope after it picked up a drop from the drink.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I leaked the restitution talks because quiet diplomacy had become an excuse for endless delay. That breach of confidence is mine. The Registrar's secure fax log shows my restitution packet transmitting throughout the poisoning window. I broke confidence, not the law of life and death.

IF MURDERER

Sterling planned to turn a disputed object into a victory speech and months of negotiation into a public defeat. I brought him one final demand. He refused. I poisoned the cordial and discarded the stained envelope. Diplomacy failed, and I chose something much worse.